and got 14.9 per cent vote share in the 2019 Lok Sabha polls, its best performance so far.

"It's a good signal that the Catholics, traditionally Congress supporters, are no longer hostile towards us. It certainly brightens our poll prospects. In the coming days, we plan to induct prominent leaders from the community into the party fold," says a senior state BJP leader, who preferred to stay unnamed.

That said, getting the community onboard will be no easy task. For one, the state has some 26 Christian denominations, many of whom do not see eye to eye with each other. This is the case even among the Catholics whom the party is focusing on. After becoming state in-charge, senior BJP leader Prakash Javadekar floated a party-backed Christian pressure group, the Bharatiya Christian Sangamam (BCS). It held its first convention in Kalamassery near Kochi on September 17, 2022, but has been silent since. Javadekar has urged outreach efforts, with BJP leaders and the cadre visiting Christian homes during Christmas and Easter to build goodwill.

PM Modi will be visiting the state again in April, and state BJP sources say he will be unveiling a "grand strategy to capture Kerala". Former Left Front convenor and CPI(M) politburo member A. Vijayaraghavan is not so convinced it will yield results. "Kerala dumps the BJP in elections because the people know they will stoop to any level to achieve their ends. Winning over the minorities in Kerala, especially the Christians, will remain a pipe-dream for Modi and Shah. This land will never celebrate their communal agenda," he says. Be that as it may, if the BJP manages even two seats in 2024, it will have taken a big step towards realising its dream of making Kerala a saffron ally. ■

– with Anilesh S. Mahajan



MILIND SHELTE

MAHA OUTREACH Uddhav Thackeray with Prakash Ambedkar

MAHARASHTRA

UDDHAV'S MEGA MINORITY RAPPORT

By Dhaval Kulkarni

Desperate times call for desperate measures. Around two decades after he first launched a short-lived project to expand the Shiv Sena's base, Uddhav Thackeray has revived his attempts to forge a wider rainbow coalition and take his faction of the party—the Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray)—beyond its core Maharashtrian support base.

The party hopes that this effort, which has seen the Sena revive its outreach to Buddhist Dalits, Muslims and Hindi speakers in Mumbai, will help them gain incremental votes from the "majority of the minority," as it fights to retain control over the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC)—India's richest civic body—which is vital to stay relevant after the debilitating split in the party. The BJP and Chief Minister Eknath Shinde, who induced a vertical split in the party's legislative and parliamentary wings, are girding their loins to wrest the BMC from the Sena. The Election Commission has recognised the Shinde faction as the official Shiv Sena and allocated it the party name, as well as the bow and arrow symbol.

In 2003, Uddhav, then the newly-appointed working president of the Shiv Sena, launched two major campaigns. These were the 'Shivshakti-Bhimshakti' initiative to reach out to Buddhist Dalits, with whom the Sena once had a bristling relationship, and 'Mee Mumbaikar' to strike roots among other linguistic denominations, especially the growing Hindi speakers in Mumbai, with an eye on the assembly polls the next year.

While 'Shivshakti-Bhimshakti' met with limited success, 'Mee Mumbaikar' floundered after activists of the Bharatiya Vidyarthi Sena, the Sena's student wing, then led by Uddhav's estranged cousin Raj Thackeray, attacked railway job aspirants from North India near Mumbai. This led to a backlash from North Indian voters in the 2004 assembly polls, which contributed to the defeat of the Shiv Sena-BJP

THE EX-CM HAS REVIVED HIS ATTEMPTS TO TAKE HIS PARTY BEYOND ITS CORE MAHARASHTRIAN SUPPORT BASE